56 Publishing an excavation archive without a server: GeoContext and GeoContext Storybook

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Publishing an excavation archive as an interactive map normally requires a server, a build pipeline and someone to maintain both — costs that outlive most project funding. GeoContext removes them: a declarative geocontext.json at the root of a public GitHub repository is read at runtime, over a public CDN, by an Apache-2.0 engine (MapLibre or Leaflet, plugin-driven, with OGC WMS and terrain built in). No build step, no account, no hosting. The repository is the publication; git supplies versioning and provenance, and the map is a view over it.

We present the format and the engine, and how they carry a legacy archive at full scale: an early twentieth-century excavation, re-georeferenced, published as thematic layers — features, structures, palaeo-environment, ancient coastline, settlement — and, for each of more than a thousand features, the original field sketch, the excavation record inline, tabular metadata, bibliography and source documents. A Frictionless Data Package v2 descriptor keeps the repository machine-validatable outside the map.

We then outline the tools that have grown around the format. GeoContext Storybook turns that repository into a longform article: a story.json extends the map unchanged, prose scrolls in a column while camera, layers and basemap follow it, and a tour block emits one section per feature — so a site narrates itself, feature by feature, out of the data rather than out of a second manuscript. One map carries many narrations. A Tauri desktop editor authors, validates and publishes the whole repository for people who do not write JSON.

We discuss the costs — CDN latency, a client-side ceiling on dataset size, no server-side query — and argue that for the long tail of legacy archives that never reach a WebGIS because nobody can fund one, static publication that anyone can fork is the appropriate FLOSS form. All Apache-2.0; citable as ISPRS Archives XLII-4/W8, 129–132.